Where to Begin With Dad's Preferences: Three First Moves for a Family With Time

In order, with why each comes first and what can be left for later.

Dad is well, and nothing needs deciding. You'd just like to start writing down how he likes his days, the way he'd tell it, and you're not sure what comes first.

Start here. Three things, in this order, at whatever pace suits you both.

1

Ask Dad about one ordinary day

Pick an easy moment, over a meal or on a drive, and ask him to walk you through a usual day: how the morning starts, when he eats, what the evening looks like. The Conversation Project's workbook asks it as “What does a good day look like for you?” Jot down his phrases as he says them. If he'd sooner skip a question, skip it. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Everything else on the page comes from what he tells you. It can't be written from memory, even a good one.

2

Read it back, and ask who he's happy to have see it

Show him what you wrote, or read it aloud, and ask what you got wrong. Change it while he's sitting there. Then ask who he'd be comfortable having read a page like this, and write his answer at the bottom. AARP's planning guide for families says a plan should never be made without the participation, knowledge and consent of the person it's about. We'd hold a page of notes about him to the same rule. [2] [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A page he has corrected is his. Until he's seen it, it's still your version of him.

3

Put a date on it, and agree when you'll look again

Write “as of” and today's date at the top. Then agree with Dad on a time to go over it together again; a note in the calendar for next year is enough. The Conversation Project's workbook says people's preferences often change as their health changes or as time goes by, and suggests coming back to see whether the answers have changed. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A date tells a reader how fresh the page is, and a plan to look again keeps today's answers from being treated as permanent.

What can be left for later

- The rest of his day and his week. One ordinary day is plenty for a first conversation, and the others can follow.
- A finished, tidy profile. A page of notes in his words is the right size for now.
- Anything about his diet or health that came from a doctor. Note where it's written down and keep it on its own list, apart from what he likes. Questions about it go to his doctor or pharmacist.
- What he'd want in a situation the two of you haven't talked about. Leave it blank. A guess isn't his answer.
- Any decision about care. None is needed, and nothing on this page makes one.

No clock on any of it

None of these three moves has a deadline. The Conversation Project's workbook says to take your time, and that it doesn't all need doing in one sitting. If a first try goes nowhere, AARP's guide suggests trying again and starting small, with just one thing.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't decide what Dad would want in a situation he hasn't talked about, turn anything he likes into an instruction, or produce a finished profile. It puts three first moves in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked Dad about an ordinary day, read it back to him and put a date on the page. The care interview gives those notes a home: it walks you through the rest of his situation area by area, keeps track of what came from him and when, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The good-day question, skipping a question, asking how much he wants others to know and coming back to the answers over time follow The Conversation Project's workbook; we've drawn only on its everyday pages. Making nothing about a person without his knowledge and consent, and trying again in a small way, follow AARP's planning guide for families. The order is ours.

1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families